

STATE REVIEW LEARNINGS:

TEACH FOR AMERICA

ALTERNATIVE

On-Site Review: February 5–6, 2024

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

The report uses evidence from both state data collection and an onsite review to examine educator preparation program performance. The information in this report is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

This report rates the EPP on all three Standards of the Arkansas Education Preparation Provider State Review Framework, which are fundamental to support teacher candidates in their journey to becoming successful teachers who meet the needs of students in Arkansas:

- Standard 1, "Candidate Recruitment and Completion," is rated primarily with quantitative data from state data collection.
- For Standard 2, "Preparing Candidates Effectively," criteria to assess performance resulted from multiple conversations with a group of stakeholders that included teacher preparation program deans, candidates, current school leaders & teachers, recent graduates, and DESE staff.
- The ratings for Standard 3, "Supporting Workforce Needs," is based on state data reporting.

Performance Levels are defined as follows:

Performance Level	Average Score Equivalent
EXCEEDS	Average score equivalent to exceeds on two of three standards or indicators
MEETS	Average score equivalent to meets on all three standards or indicators
APPROACHING	Average score equivalent to approaching on one standards or indicator and meets on the other two
BELOW	Average score equivalent to below on one standard or indicator and approaching on the other two

TEACH FOR AMERICA

ALTERNATIVE

Overall Performance Level		
APPROACHING		
Performance Levels by Standard		
Standard 1: Recruitment & Completion	Standard 2: Preparing Candidates Effectively	Standard 3: Supporting Workforce Needs
MEETS	APPROACHING	APPROACHING

STANDARD 1: RECRUITMENT & COMPLETION

Standard 1 Performance Level		
MEETS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 1.1 Plans	Indicator 1.2 Recruitment	Indicator 1.3 Completion
MEETS	APPROACHING	EXCEEDS
Recommendations		
TFA-Delta is exceeding targets for recruiting candidates into certification shortage areas. The EPP also does a strong job ensuring that enrollees complete the program. Unfortunately, TFA-Delta's overall enrollment has declined over the past three years. Recommendations include setting and meeting annual recruiting targets to meet Arkansas' workforce needs, especially in shortage areas (<i>Focus Area: Criteria 1.2a</i>).		

INDICATOR 1.1: PLANS

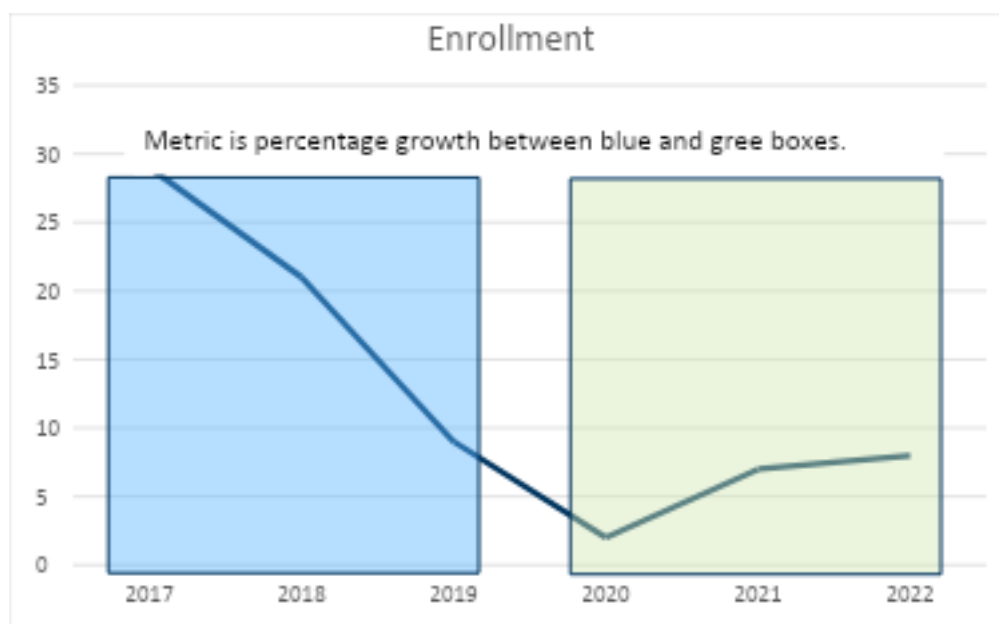
Criteria 1.1a	
Programs have formal plans to meet the targets described in the state review framework (I.e.; Standards 1-3) and show evidence of acting on their plans	
Performance Level	Explanation
MEETS	EPPs were not asked to submit formal plans to meet the state review framework targets or to show evidence of acting on their plans as part of the Spring 2024 review cycle. As a result, all EPPs in this cycle will receive a rating of MEETS.

INDICATOR 1.2: RECRUITMENT

Criteria 1.2a

Programs meet annual recruitment targets that align with their
program size and Arkansas's workforce needs

Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Growth in 3yr Average Enrollment	Performance Level
Percentage growth in 3yr average enrollment	10%	-71.2%	BELOW

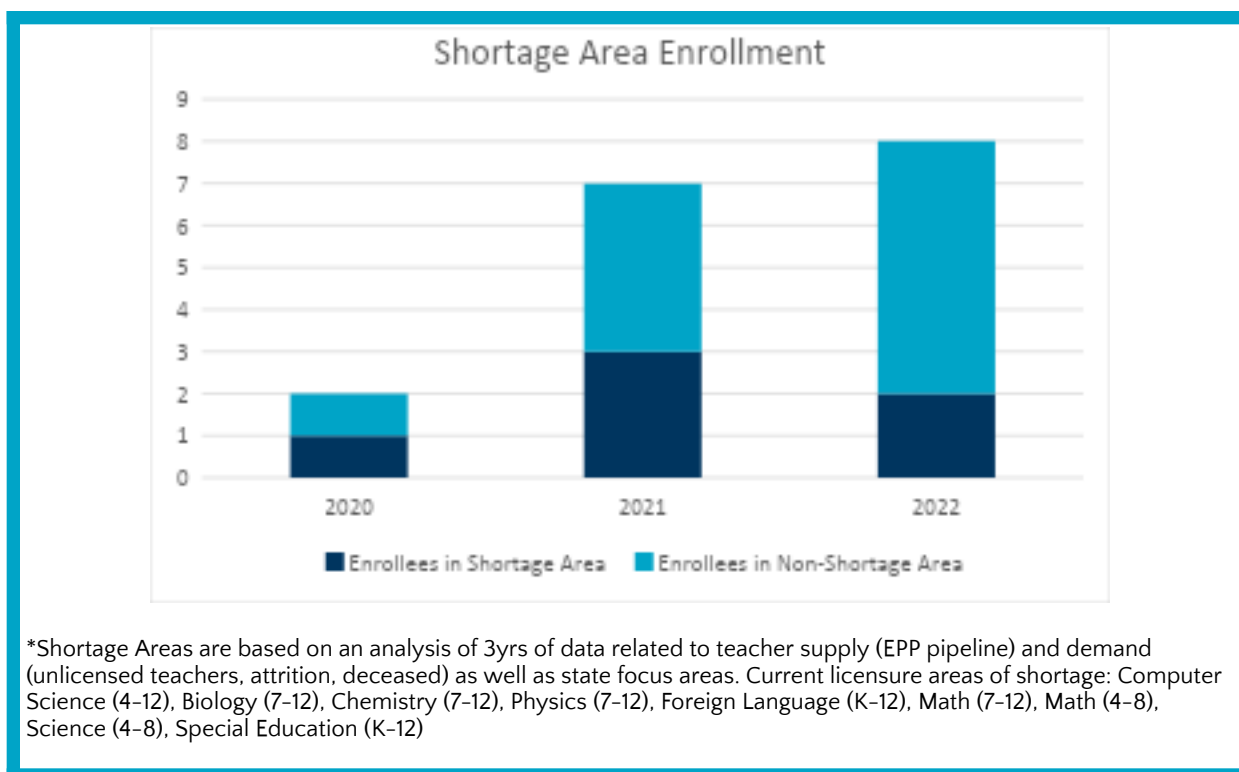


*The enrollment growth target was established with the aim of closing the sizeable gap between EPP completers and those leaving the classroom over the next 10yrs. EPPs can earn a "Meets" rating by demonstrating positive program enrollment growth (i.e., growth greater than zero) and an "Exceeds" rating by demonstrating growth greater than 10 percent.

Criteria 1.2b

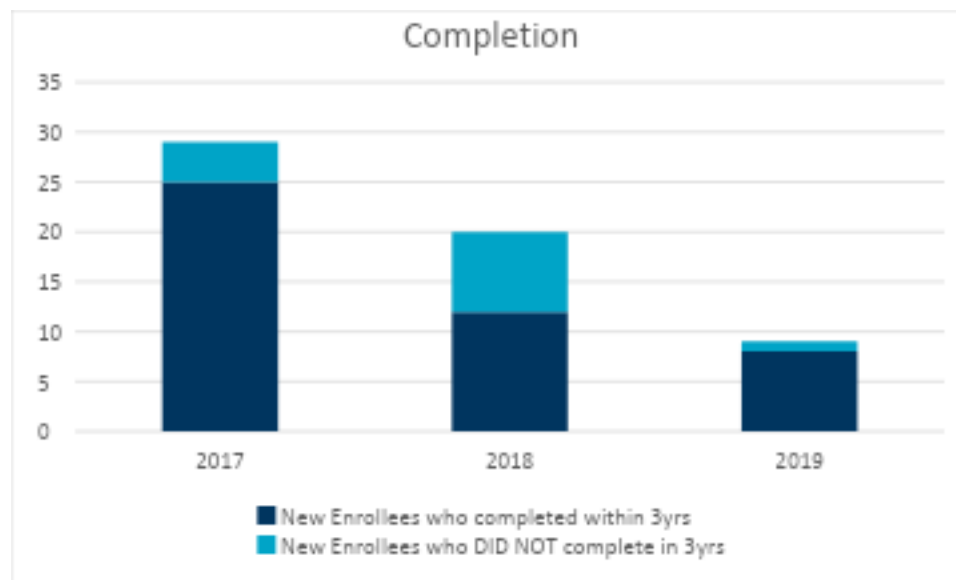
Programs recruit candidates for Arkansas certification shortage areas
in proportion to the need

Metric	Target	EPP's Percent of new enrollees in Shortage Areas	Performance Level
Percentage of program candidates recruited in shortage areas	24%	35%	EXCEEDS



INDICATOR 1.3: COMPLETION

Criteria 1.3a			
Candidates have high rates of completion			
Metric	Target	EPP's 3-Year Completion Rate	Performance Level
Three-year average completion rate	75%	78%	EXCEEDS



Standard 2: PREPARING CANDIDATES EFFECTIVELY

Standard 2 Performance Level		
APPROACHING		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 2.1 Coursework	Indicator 2.2 Clinical Experiences	Indicator 2.3 Development
APPROACHING	APPROACHING	MEETS
Recommendations		
The alignment of coursework and clinical experience are strengths at TFA-Delta, as well as candidate development and support, with most candidates achieving program milestones in coursework and clinical experience. Candidates who struggle with coursework and clinical experience are provided individualized support plans to stay on track. High-performing candidates have additional development and opportunities to continue to grow as educators through partnerships with Arkansas-based leadership development programs. Recommendations center around incorporating Arkansas initiatives into coursework and developing a deeper partnership with districts/schools to co-construct a more supportive clinical experience for Corps Members (CMs). 1. Within coursework and syllabi, increase explicit references and models of Arkansas-specific, vertical alignment of Arkansas K-12 content standards. This will enable candidates to see how their courses help them build the knowledge and skills for licensure and day-one readiness within Arkansas. (<i>Focus Area: Criteria 2.1a Metric 2</i>) 2. Formalize and standardize communication channels with all districts/schools where participants teach to ensure two-way communication around candidate needs, experiences, and effectiveness. In addition to TFA-supported coaching, an effective partnership between the district/school mentors and TFA will be important for the CM experience. (<i>Focus Area: Criteria 2.2b Metric 2, Criteria 2.2c Metric 1</i>) 3. Begin preparing now to meet the state's one-year residency requirement that will apply to spring 2027 completers and beyond. Formalize systems and structures to ensure that the mentor teachers and clinical supervisors working with candidates in the building are experienced, very effective and, by the 2026-2027 school year, have received DESE-recognized coaching training. (<i>Focus Area: Criteria 2.2b, 2.3c Metric 2</i>)		

INDICATOR 2.1: COURSEWORK

Criteria 2.1a Candidates receive high-quality program coursework that is evidence-based	
Performance Level	Explanation
	Candidates receive some high-quality program coursework that is evidence-based. TFA-Delta coursework clearly and intentionally incorporates nationally recognized best practices around content instruction, as evidenced in the "Content Learning Scope and Sequence" for each certification area. It includes content sections,

APPROACHING	curriculum, planning series, and content and pedagogy step-backs. Recognizing and using high-quality instructional materials was observed in the Curricular Literacy Overview, which teaches candidates to evaluate open-source instructional materials for quality. Eureka Math and Expeditionary Learning, two HQIMs, were also intentionally incorporated into Practicum coursework. During Practicum, all teachers are trained in Barksdale Reading to ensure awareness of the Science of Reading. Multiple examples of evidence-based practices were observed in the Course on assessment in elementary grades. The instructor used a “think and discuss” strategy to engage candidate thinking using essential questions about using standards. One participant in the coursework focus group gave examples of best practices, such as learning techniques like “turn and talk.” Coursework somewhat familiarizes candidates with Arkansas K-12 Standards throughout all grade bands within the licensure area. In the documentation submitted, the Eureka Math Alignment to Arkansas Standards shows which components of Eureka Math address each AR Math standard. However, no evidence was submitted for other subjects. There was no reference to vertical integration of standards throughout syllabi, assignments, or coursework. No evidence was submitted that candidates have opportunities to integrate standards vertically throughout all grade bands.
Criteria 2.1b Candidates' coursework supports their development as a teacher	
APPROACHING	Candidates' coursework somewhat supports their development as a teacher. Courses are somewhat sequenced across programs of study to build off previous coursework, providing candidates an opportunity to show proficiency. The documentation submitted showed inconsistent evidence of course progression and rigor. The Corps Member Program Outcomes Roadmap shows a progressive expectation increase across the two-year experience as candidates show growth and proficiency. Pre-Service and Practicum Scope and Sequence and Content Coursework clearly outlines an increase in rigor. However, the expectations for years 1 and 2 are focused on coaching, and while the candidate development offerings/classes are comprehensive and responsive, they do not intentionally build on each other to represent an increase in rigor. Coursework incorporates Arkansas Teaching Standards in a way that partially develops candidates to meet the competencies of their required licensure area. The coursework focus group participants did not recognize the Arkansas Teaching Standards. In the Coursework observation on Assessment in Elementary Education, it was observed that the instructor used AR K-12 content standards across ELA and math at different grade levels; however, there was no evidence specific references to the Arkansas Teaching Standards or rubrics that assess them (e.g., TESS). Coursework is clearly and intentionally aligned to clinical experience. For example, in the observation on Assessment in Elementary Education, the candidates used the actual student assessments from the classrooms the CMs were teaching as content. In the documentation submitted by the EPP, all outcomes, templates, coursework, and coaching overviews were directly connected to the classroom experience (either in preservice or in years 1 and 2), for example, “Goal Setting Guidance,” “Prep Primer and Protocol,” and the “Learning Plan Environment Template and Overview.” Candidates consistently have opportunities to reflect on connections between their clinical experience and coursework with their MDLD (clinical supervisor and course instructor). Coursework focuses on the individual candidate’s teaching practice in the classroom context, and the candidate receives targeted feedback and coaching, during which candidates consistently have opportunities to reflect on and articulate the alignment.

Criteria 2.1c

Candidates are provided with knowledgeable and effective course instructors

MEETS

Candidates are provided with knowledgeable and effective course instructors.

Most course instructors show deep knowledge of Arkansas K12 standards, content knowledge, and content pedagogy.

The Assessment in Elementary Ed observation showed evidence that the course instructor used AR K-12 content standards across ELA and math at different grade levels. In the observation of "Secondary Math," the course instructor utilized multiple modalities in content delivery, fostered student engagement, presented content well-structured and organized, emphasized reflectivity, and facilitated collaboration among candidates.

Most course instructors have a proven history and/or show evidence of strong facilitation of coursework and providing feedback and support. Instructors have been coaching for a combined 14 years in the Delta, and reviewers observed strong facilitation and feedback. Both instructors hold licensure and receive Professional development. Teachstone's CLASS Training to support strong interactions for grades K-4 is renewed annually. In the observation of "Content 2 Hallmark," student engagement was strong, and multiple opportunities were presented for questions and discussion as a means of providing feedback and support for candidate learning.

INDICATOR 2.2: CLINICAL EXPERIENCES

Indicator 2.2a

Candidates are provided clinical experiences throughout their program that support their development as a teacher

Performance Level

Explanation

APPROACHING

Candidates are provided some clinical experiences throughout their program that support their development as teachers.

The overall sequence of clinical experiences from the summer to the second year of clinical clearly and intentionally builds off previous experiences and includes opportunities for learning and development.

The Corps Member Program Outcomes Roadmap also lays out clear statements of what each CM should be able to do after Pre-Service, the first 90 days, End of Year 1, and End of Year 2. In the program director focus group, it was explained that the overall sequence of clinical experiences begins with a practicum in which students are placed in a classroom with a mentor teacher for three weeks during summer school. This is followed by two years of supervised experience as the teacher of record in a K-12 classroom. This provides extensive opportunities for learning and development, accompanied by coaching, in the first two years of teaching.

However, the overall variety of clinical experiences provides only some opportunities for candidates to work with students with varied learning needs.

In one of the focus groups, an alum talked about the structure of the summer practicum. During the summer, CMs do not necessarily teach the subject in which they will be licensed, and they do not have a lot of choice in their placement; they do have opportunities to work with students with varied learning. In the Program Director focus group, one participant explained that during the practicum (pre-service), candidates are placed in classroom settings that may or may not reflect their intended licensure pathway. During Years 1 and 2, they are assigned based on district hiring needs. Therefore, candidates do not appear to have much opportunity to be exposed to various experiences.

Criteria 2.2b

Candidates across the program are provided with an effective clinical internship

APPROACHING

Candidates across the program are provided with somewhat of an effective clinical internship.

Some experienced mentor teachers are equipped and demonstrate that they have the coaching skills to properly support and develop a candidate's pedagogical development. During the pre-service practicum over the summer, mentor teachers are selected from the school site's current staff who have existing relationships with the students and are familiar with the school's policies. This selection is made in partnership with the site's principal, who recommends faculty who have demonstrated teaching excellence and leadership potential. Once these faculty are selected, they are trained by TFA in best practices for instructional coaching. It should be noted that by 2026-2027, experienced mentor teachers working with year-long residents must have received DESE-recognized coaching training. However, there is no formal process to select experienced mentor teachers once candidates serve as Teachers of Record in years 1-2. Instead, in the TFA model, they receive regular coaching and feedback from their MDLD (clinical supervisor). MDLDs start coaching their participants during the summer Practicum and support them throughout their two years. Note that the [Arkansas Novice Teacher Mentoring Manual](#) requires that "Novice teachers enrolled in an alternate EPP should be supported by an EPP clinical supervisor in addition to their district assigned experienced mentor teacher."

MDLDs (clinical supervisors) have a proven history and show evidence of effective instructional practices and coaching with a positive impact. They both have master's degrees and are licensed teachers with 4+ years of experience. They receive additional development and support from TFA. One clinical supervisor talked about having biweekly check-ins with her manager. They have monthly meetings with all coaches in the region and quarterly meetings with all coaches in TFA.

The clinical supervisors are continuously trained through TFA to develop their effectiveness further. As full-time employees with a crucial role in the organization, the clinical supervisors (MDLDs) play the greatest role in supporting their participants. In the past year, MDLDs have received training in various pedagogical methods and resources such as Teachstone's CLASS, University of Chicago's Cultivate, and Centering Voices so that they can bring these approaches to their CMs. They also receive foundational training in the science of reading to support teachers in Years 1 and 2. In the past, MDLDs have received a variety of trainings that provide opportunity to develop coaching skills, such as Together Leader training and Transformational Coaching training with Bright Morning Consulting. Internal performance review processes stress the importance of continual development, so many coaches also seek out training in areas of growth or interest. In recent years, TFA coaches have joined a reimagining education lab, Rural School Leadership Academy, and received development through the Delta Fellows program at Delta State University.

Candidates sometimes receive high-quality feedback. The observation rubric used to provide feedback to candidates is named TOR and was cross walked with TESS. The crosswalk shows close alignment. However, the TOR has not been approved by DESE as a high-quality feedback tool. Note that the Aspiring Teacher Rubric must be in use by the 2024-25 academic year by all EPPs. Prior to that time, EPPs may use the TESS framework or another aligned tool.

During the summer Practicum, candidates receive frequent, consistent feedback based on a rubric that is both written and oral, nearly every day. However, that changes during Years 1 and 2. In the clinical supervisor focus group and the clinical experience focus group, participants corroborated that the clinical supervisor meets with a CM at least once a month (sometimes face-to-face, other times virtually) and has office hours.

One focus group participant mentioned they received oral feedback from their clinical supervisor that was linked to student learning. This aligns with documents submitted,

	such as the MDLD Observation Guide that clinical supervisors use to debrief a lesson. In contrast, there was no evidence submitted of written feedback to a teaching candidate except for an example of handwritten personal notes left after an observation. However, one CM talked about receiving feedback on a spreadsheet from their clinical supervisor, who emails, texts, and calls to debrief the ratings.
Criteria 2.2c Strong partnerships exist between the EPP and K12 schools and districts that facilitate the development of strong candidates	
APPROACHING	Strong partnerships exist between the EPP and K12 schools and districts that help develop strong candidates. Collaborative processes are in place with most districts/schools to co-construct the clinical internship over the summer practicum for candidates, including experienced mentor teachers and clinical supervisors. The documentation submitted shows evidence of long-standing relationships with partner schools. Survey results show that requests for TFA teachers exceed the number of CMs available yearly. For the summer practicum, there is an MOU that outlines the expectations for the CM and the partner school. Some collaborative processes are in place that support and develop effective clinical supervisors. Clinical supervisors receive training during the summer. The 2023 Staff Training Overview document specifies the number of hours (about 10 per week) from April to May that clinical supervisors attend in preparation for the summer practicum. It also describes the staff training priorities and approaches to support role-specific training. However, there is no evidence of formal support or collaboration between the K12 school and clinical supervisor, most likely because schools are not formally in session over the summer. In one focus group, a clinical supervisor said that they connect with building personnel regularly during the year (building admin, instructional coach, EMT), but no evidence was submitted of intentional communication and alignment on development goals for the CM.

INDICATOR 2.3: DEVELOPMENT

Criteria 2.3a Candidates are successful with their program coursework	
Performance Level	Explanation
MEETS	Candidates are successful with their program coursework. Most candidates show proficiency in coursework requirements. Candidates do not earn grades but show proficiency in coursework by completing all required program components. The specific elements that are tracked are passing the relevant PRAXIS, attendance at required training/classes during Preservice, completion of Practicum clinical teaching experience, attendance at coaching meetings during Practicum, Year 1 and Year 2, submitting monthly data during Years 1-2, completing CLASS/Cultivate training, participation in Better Lesson coaching structure, allowing observations and completing any pre- or post-work required by coach, and attendance at thrice-yearly Summits. The evidence submitted showed that 81% of candidates met the requirements to complete the program. Candidates are consistently provided with an individualized support plan called a CMIP if their coursework requirements are not on track. Documentation of the process was submitted, and there is a stated goal of coming together to assess progress towards the improvement goals.
Criteria 2.3b Candidates are successful in their clinical internship	

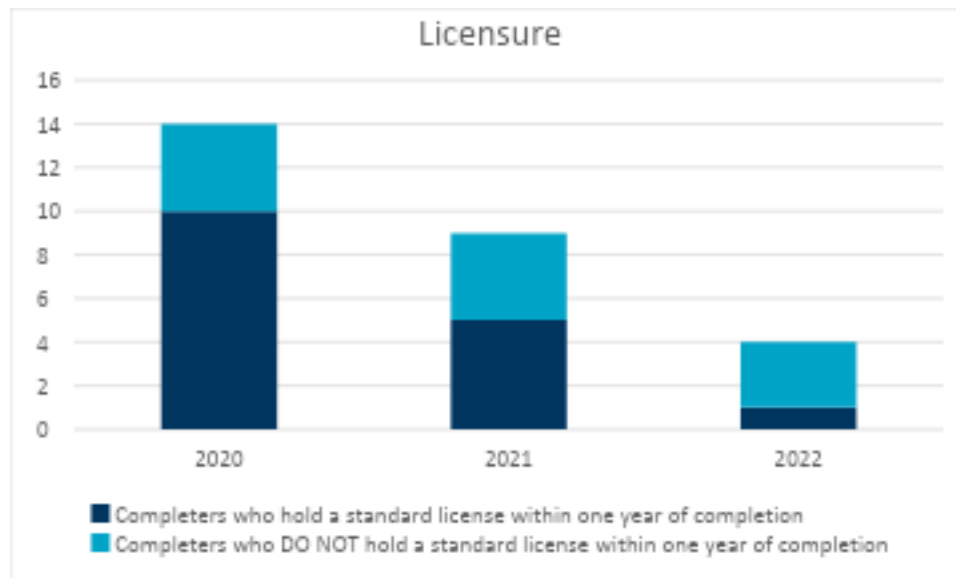
MEETS	Candidates are successful in their clinical internship. Most candidates meet clinical experience goals and milestones. There is adequate evidence that candidates can impact student growth. In one focus group, CMs talked about keeping a spreadsheet of student progress and working towards student mastery of content in their classroom. In evidence submitted, Data collection from the 2022-2023 school year shows that 46% of TFA candidates' students showed over one year of academic growth, with 27% showing over 1.5 years. Based on the SEED Data, 46% of CMs had at least one year of SEED growth (EOY Class Avg Growth). and 27% of CMs had 1.5+ years of EOY Class Average Growth. Most candidates receive an " effective " score on TFA's version of TESS at the end of their clinical internship. In TFA's version of TESS, called TOR, all CMs were formally observed three times a year and were in the 90th percentile by May. All candidates with varied needs are provided with the support they need, including-struggling candidates who are consistently provided with an individualized support plan if their development in the clinical internship is not on track. The EPP showed evidence that they provide their candidates with excellent support during their learning by requiring the students to set goals and monitor their progress toward those goals. The EPP coaches provide students with support sessions at least once per month where they can reach out for assistance, mental health support, and encouragement from their coaches. The sessions also allow the candidates to share and learn from their peers' experiences. In the evidence submitted, the "CMIP Guiding Principles" lay out clear guidelines and guidance for improvement plans. Coaches communicate clearly and frequently with CMs about coursework expectations. CMs supported this. One CM talked about receiving feedback on a spreadsheet from their clinical supervisor, who emails, texts, and calls to debrief the ratings. Most high-performing candidates receive opportunities and feedback that encourage their retention. Teachers who are high performing have opportunities for growth through TFA, such as employment at Summer Practicum, support to work toward National Board Certification, and leadership pathway programs. TFA partners with the Clinton School of Public Service to help funnel high-performing candidates into higher education programs in the state of Arkansas to continue to deepen their impact. Another program for alumni is the Rural School Leadership Academy, which helps prepare teachers in rural areas to become school leaders.
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STANDARD 3: SUPPORTING WORKFORCE NEEDS

Standard 3 Performance Level		
APPROACHING		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 3.1 Licensure	Indicator 3.2 Employment	Indicator 3.3 Effectiveness
APPROACHING	APPROACHING	APPROACHING
Recommendations		
Teach for America produces a high proportion of enrollees who are provisionally licensed but can do a better job at ensuring that they go on to obtain their standard license in Arkansas. Many of their completers who work in Arkansas public schools are serving high-priority schools, however more of their completers should be working in Arkansas public schools and staying longer. The effectiveness of Teach for America completers is partially unknown due to lack of responses for the School Leader and Completer surveys, but the value-added data for completers suggests that Teach for America teachers' impact on student growth could be improved.		

INDICATOR 3.1: LICENSURE

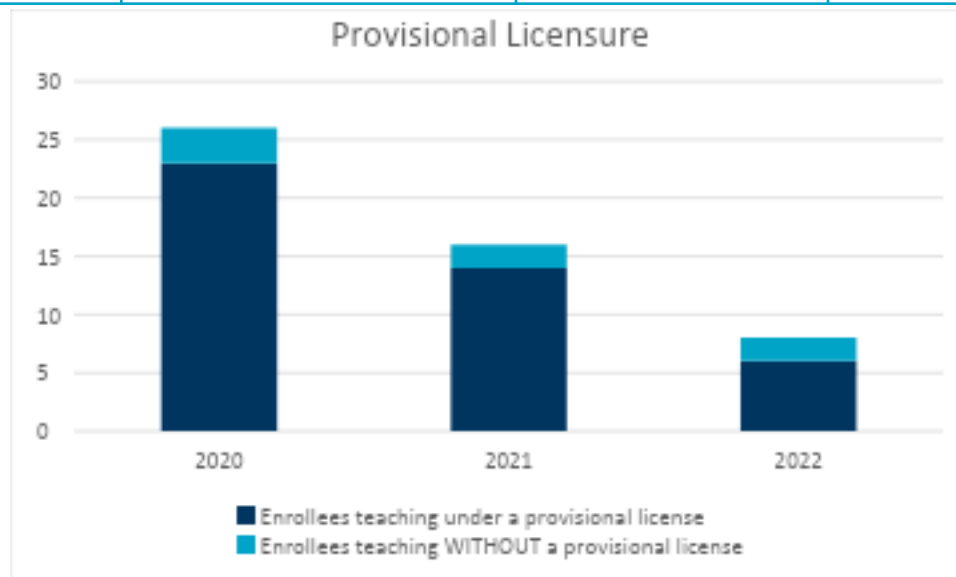
Criteria 3.1a			
A high proportion of program candidates obtain a standard license			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who have earned a standard license	76%	59%	BELOW



Criteria 3.1b

A high proportion of alternative route enrollees are provisionally licensed

Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of employed alternative route enrollees who are provisionally licensed	69%	86%	EXCEEDS



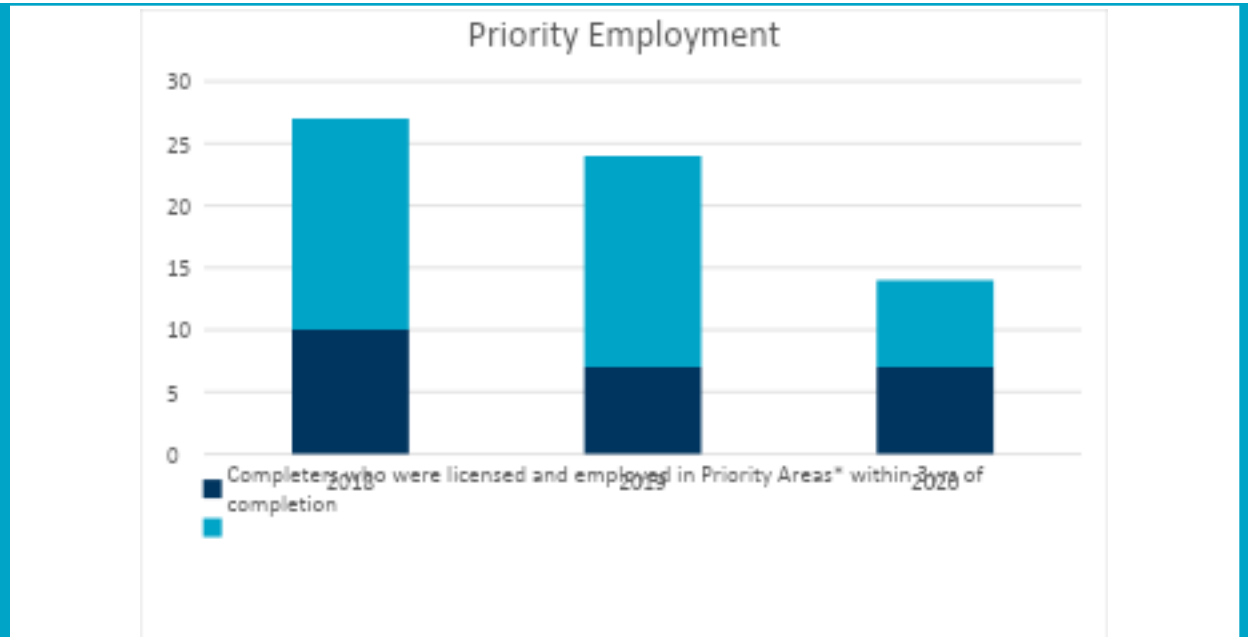
Criteria 3.1c

A high proportion of traditional program candidates pass the content exam in their area on the first try

Metric	Target	EPP's First Time Pass Percentage	Performance Level
Percentage of first-time licensure exam test takers that pass on their first try	65%	n/a	n/a

INDICATOR 3.2: EMPLOYMENT

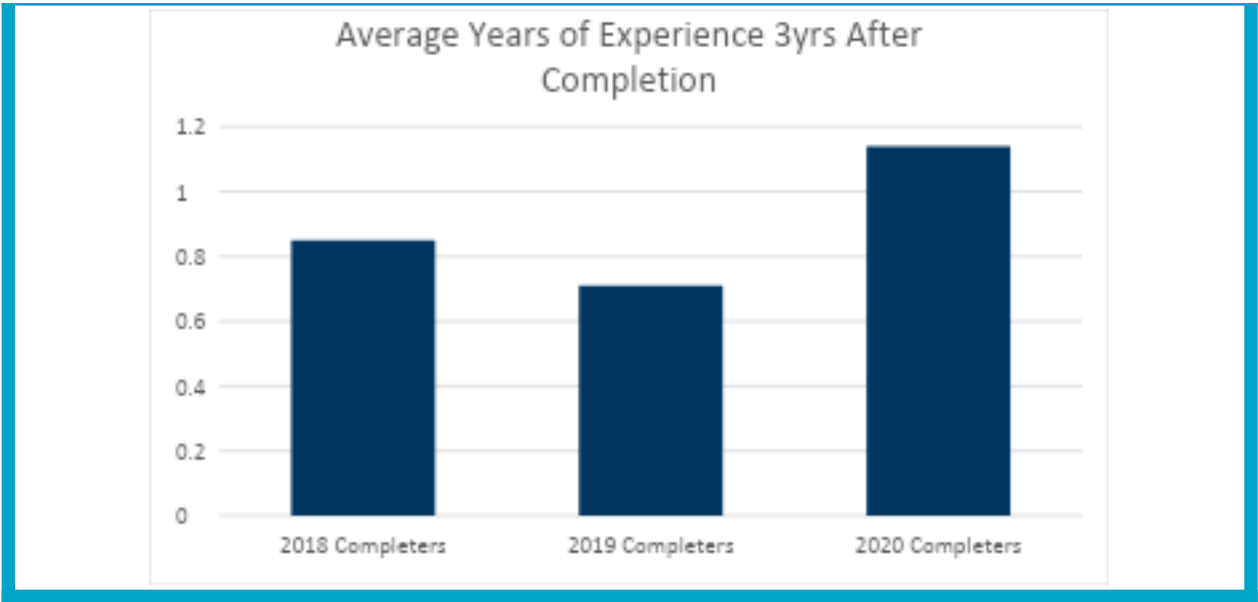
Criteria 3.2a																			
A high proportion of completers are employed in Arkansas public schools																			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed	Performance Level																
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in Arkansas public schools in their first three years after completion	64%	38.5%	BELOW																
Employment <table border="1"> <caption>Employment Data (Approximate Values)</caption> <thead> <tr> <th>Year</th> <th>Completers who were licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion</th> <th>Completers who WERE NOT licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion</th> <th>Total</th> </tr> </thead> <tbody> <tr> <td>2018</td> <td>11</td> <td>16</td> <td>27</td> </tr> <tr> <td>2019</td> <td>7</td> <td>17</td> <td>24</td> </tr> <tr> <td>2020</td> <td>7</td> <td>7</td> <td>14</td> </tr> </tbody> </table> ■ Completers who were licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion ■ Completers who WERE NOT licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion				Year	Completers who were licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion	Completers who WERE NOT licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion	Total	2018	11	16	27	2019	7	17	24	2020	7	7	14
Year	Completers who were licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion	Completers who WERE NOT licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion	Total																
2018	11	16	27																
2019	7	17	24																
2020	7	7	14																
Criteria 3.2b																			
A high proportion of completers work in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects																			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed Priority	Performance Level																
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects in their first three years after completion	40%	36.9%	MEETS																



*Priority Employment is employment in a high need subject area and/or geographical shortage area. Shortage Areas are based on an analysis of 3yrs of data related to teacher supply (EPP pipeline) and demand (unlicensed teachers, attrition, deceased) and state focus areas.

Current subject shortage areas for employment: Computer Science, Secondary Science, Foreign Language, Secondary Math, Middle School Math, Middle School Science, and Special Education.
 Current geographical shortage areas are school districts located in the following co-op regions: Arkansas River ESC, Great Rivers ESC, Pulaski Co Schools, Southeast AR ESC.

Criteria 3.2c			
Program completers remain in the classroom for multiple years			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Years of Experience, 3 Years After Completion	Performance Level
Program completers' average licensed teaching experience in Arkansas's public schools 3 years after completion	1.7	0.86	APPROACHING



INDICATOR 3.3: EFFECTIVENESS

Criteria 3.3a			
School leaders rate program completers that they hire as effective classroom teachers			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
School leaders' perception of program completer effectiveness based on responses to the EPP Completer Supervisor Survey conducted annually by DESE	81%	No responses	n/a
Criteria 3.3b			
Completers feel that their program prepared them well to be a teacher			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
Program completers' perception of how well their program prepared them to be a teacher based on responses to the EPP Completer Survey conducted annually by DESE	75%	No responses	n/a
Criteria 3.3c			
A high proportion of program completers have above-average value-added scores			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage with Average Value-Added of 80+	Performance Level
Percentage of program completers who have above-average value-added scores in their first three years after completion	43%	38%	APPROACHING

Value-Added Growth Scores

